Why the Podcast Host Is the Most Trusted Person in the World



56%

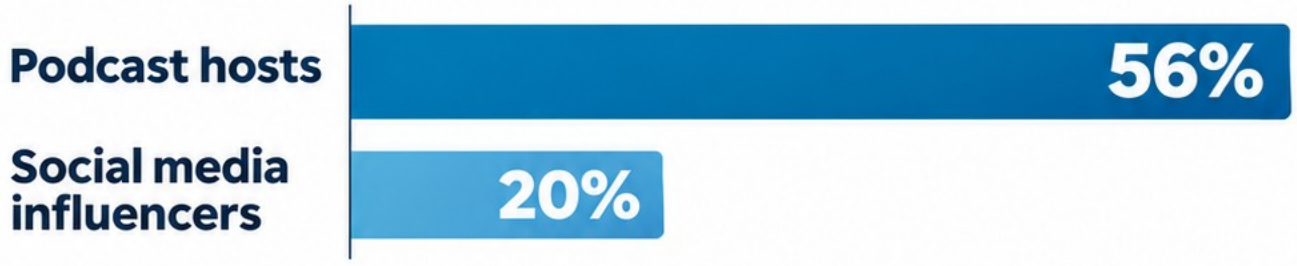
of weekly podcast consumers say podcast hosts are the type of influencer that matters most to them.

Read the study: Cumulus Media and Signal Hill Insights, Podcast Download, Fall 2025

THE HEADLINE NUMBER

One question, one clear answer

Cumulus Media and Signal Hill Insights asked weekly podcast consumers a simple question: which type of influencer matters most to you? The answer was not close.



That gap is the story. The people brands pay to reach have already chosen who they trust, and it's the person talking to them for thirty minutes, not the person flashing past them for three seconds.

For public relations, this changes the job. Influence used to be rented by the post. Now it's earned by the episode, one listener at a time, by a host the audience chose.

The host is the new influencer



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THE PATTERN

It's not one study. It's every study

The Cumulus Media finding would be interesting on its own. What makes it a shift is that every other serious study of the same question points the same way.

71%

of fans trust their favorite creator over social media influencers.

Wondery / SmithGeiger, Brand Building in the Creator Age, 2026

81%

of creator fans trust their favorite host as much as, or more than, their close friends.

Wondery / SmithGeiger, Brand Building in the Creator Age, 2026

63%

of people trust their favorite podcaster more than their favorite social media influencer.

Spotify, Global Podcast Trends Tour

33%

of podcast listeners rank podcasters among the most credible sources for product recommendations, alongside journalists and ahead of social media influencers (28%).

Acast, 2025 Podcast Pulse

Trust is moving away from the feed and toward the voice

This is not about impressions or likes. It's about genuinely developing trust through time spent.



WHY IT WORKS

Why a host earns trust

Trust is not a claim. It's an accumulation. A podcast host accumulates it in ways no other format can match.

> **A feed asks for a glance. A host asks for thirty minutes, and gets them, week after week. That is the difference between being seen and being believed.**



1 Time

On average, listeners hear about 70% of every episode. That is real time with your brand, week after week. No other format holds attention that long.

2 A person, not a feed

A listener chooses a host and comes back to the same voice. The relationship is personal before it's commercial, which is why a recommendation from a host lands like advice from a friend.

3 Consistency

The same voice, the same standard, every week. Trust is built on kept promises, and a regular episode is a promise kept on schedule.

4 Community

People rally around people. A podcast builds a community around its host, and a recommendation inside a community lands like advice from a friend, not an ad.

The threat to watch

The risk is not that people stop trusting hosts. It's that they stop listening, and copy a transcript into an AI tool instead.

HOW TO GET STARTED

Start where listeners already are

Podcast listening happens mostly inside podcast apps. That is where listeners spend by far the most time with shows, so that is where your show needs to be.

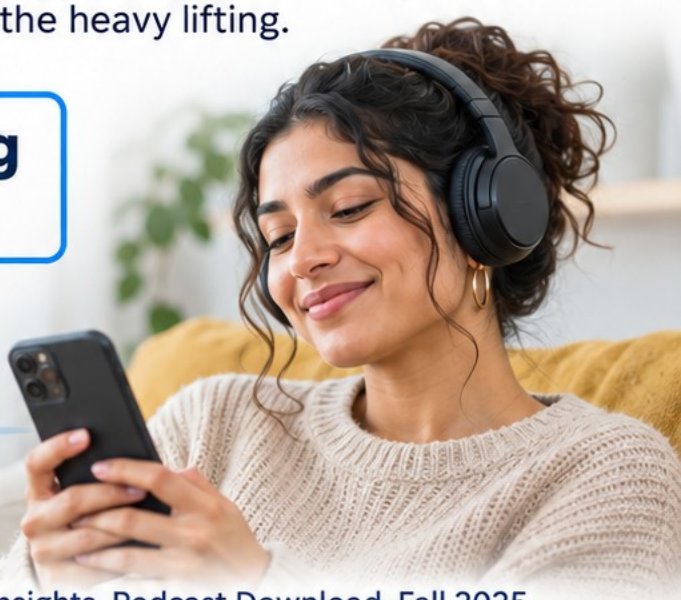
Apple Podcasts | Spotify | Pocket Casts | Castro | Overcast

And YouTube?

People absolutely spend a lot of time on YouTube, and they do watch podcasts there. But they tend to watch episodes for a shorter length of time. The deep listening happens in the audio apps, so put the full episode on YouTube too, and let the audio apps do the heavy lifting.

The majority of listening time is in audio apps

YouTube is a phenomenal discovery tool, so use it. Make the episode worth the full experience.



Read the study: Cumulus Media and Signal Hill Insights, Podcast Download, Fall 2025

THREE WAYS IN

The three real plays in podcasting

1

Put your experts on existing shows

Interview pitching. Your people go on podcasts your audience already trusts, and borrow that trust for thirty minutes. It's the fastest way in, and the cheapest. One good conversation on the right show can do more than a month of posts.

2

Place ads in podcasts

Host-read ads, read by a voice the audience already trusts. The ad works because the host works. It rents trust by the episode, and it scales.

3

Own your channel

Launch a branded podcast. Your show, your voice, your audience. It's the slowest play and the strongest one, because the trust it builds belongs to you, not to someone else's show.

The third play does something the first two cannot

A branded podcast does not borrow trust. It builds it, and the brand keeps it.



THE EVIDENCE

What a branded podcast does

The BBC commissioned neuroscience research into branded podcasts, and found they change how listeners feel about the brand itself. Five findings carry that change.

- **Branding stands out from the content**
  Brand mentions in the podcast deliver on average 16% higher engagement and 12% higher memory encoding than the surrounding content.
- **Listeners are active**
  94% of listeners consume podcasts while performing other tasks, and this mode of listening actually elevates engagement with the brand.
- **Additive to the marketing mix**
  Podcasts are consumed in ways that are additive to the marketing mix, reaching people in moments other media does not.
- **A way to reach ad avoiders**
  Podcasts are a particularly effective way to reach ad avoiders. Their engagement, emotional intensity and memory encoding around brand mentions beat TV benchmarks by at least 22%.
- **The language creates subconscious associations**
  Listeners form subconscious associations with the brand from the words they hear.

Across the study, brand metrics lifted.

Awareness up 89%, consideration up 57%, favorability up 24%, purchase intent up 14%.



Read the study: Audio: Activated · BBC, 2019

WHAT TO DO ABOUT IT

Five moves for your brand

1. **Give the trust a voice**
If your brand has something worth saying, say it in a voice people can trust. A branded podcast puts your brand inside the conversations people already trust.

2. **Design episodes to be heard**
Build episodes around a question worth thirty minutes, not a message worth a press release. If an episode can be replaced by its summary, it will be.

3. **Put a person forward**
Audiences trust people, not logos. The host is the brand in the room. Choose someone worth listening to, and let them be themselves.

4. **Measure trust, not just downloads**
Downloads count files. Trust shows up in how much of an episode people hear, whether they come back, and what they do next.

5. **Start before your competitors do**
Most PR agencies still treat podcasting as complicated. It's not. The gap is the opportunity, and it's open now.



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KEEP GOING

Keep going with Stories and Strategies

The Stories and Strategies Podcasting Newsletter is the weekly briefing for brands that use podcasting, or are thinking about it. Sign up free at **storiesandstrategies.substack.com.**

Sources

Every statistic in this report links to its study. Cumulus Media and Signal Hill Insights, Podcast Download, Fall 2025. Wondery / SmithGeiger, Brand Building in the Creator Age, 2026. Spotify, Global Podcast Trends Tour. Acast, 2025 Podcast Pulse. Audio: Activated, BBC, 2019. The 70% figure is an approximate average across published listening studies.



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